MOOD OF THE NATION

LEAD ESSAY

WARNING SIGNALS

UNEMPLOYMENT, INFLATION AND GEN Z DISCONTENT TAKE A TOLL ON THE BJP'S TALLY EVEN AS THE NDA RETAINS A COMFORTABLE MAJORITY AND PM MODI HIS POPULARITY

By **RAJ CHENGAPPA**

Just this May, Prime Minister Narendra Modi appeared more invincible than ever in his third term, as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) secured a landslide victory in the West Bengal election. Not only was it a historic first for the BJP in a key state of the east, it also capped a string of impressive wins the party had registered in assembly polls in Bihar, Maharashtra, Assam, Haryana and Delhi after a setback in the 2024 general election.

The Bengal sweep saw the BJP and its allies extend their rule to 22 of the country's 31 states and Union Territories with legislatures. In doing so, the party appeared to have shaken off the uncertainty triggered by its failure to secure a majority in the Lok Sabha election, when its tally of 240 seats fell 32 short of the 272 needed for a simple majority, forcing it to rely on its National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partners to form the government at the Centre.

So, the Modi government wasn't exactly prepared when a series of adverse circumstances put both the prime minister and the ruling party on the back foot. Modi would increasingly find himself caught between a rock and a hard place—or as the Hindi saying goes, *aage kuan, peechhe khai* (a well ahead, a ditch behind)—both at home and abroad.

Just as the BJP celebrations in Bengal were reaching a crescendo, trouble began brewing for the Modi government. The leak of the question paper for the 2026 National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) for medical seats, held on May 3, forced the Union education ministry to cancel the exam. It gave the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), born of an offhand remark, the perfect opportunity to organise a massive protest at Jantar Mantar, which would culminate in the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Scarcely had that crisis receded when inflationary pressures began to mount again following the breakdown of the memorandum of understanding between Iran and the United States, prolonging their debilitating standoff in the Strait of Hormuz and pushing up crude oil prices for India. Adding to the government's concerns are the threat of El Niño and the prospect of erratic rainfall, fuelling fears of a sharp dip in agricultural output.

POLY-CRISIS IMPACT ON THE PM

The impact of this poly-crisis on the popularity of the prime minister and the ruling party shows up vividly in the latest INDIA TODAY-CVoter biannual Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll. According to the survey, were a Lok Sabha election held now, the BJP would win 261 seats, 11 short of a simple majority on its own. That is a drop of 26 seats from the January MOTN, which had projected a far more comfortable tally of 287 for the BJP. More disconcertingly for the party, the poll indicates that without its victory in Bengal,